Sarah Syed, BS

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Education

Tufts University Medford, MA 2020 – 2024

BS Psychology & BA Community Health | ***Summa Cum Laude*** ***Psychology GPA 3.98*** | ***Cumulative GPA 3.94***

Honors Thesis: *Prejudice and Bias Awareness in Anticipated Interracial Interactions* (Advised by Keith Maddox, PhD)

Awards and Honors

Student Poster Award Winner, Society of Pediatric Psychology (2024). Nominated and selected by SPP board members, honoring students who are first author of a poster presented at the annual SPP conference

Priscilla N. Dunne Prize Award, Tufts University Department of Psychology (2024). Awarded annually to an undergraduate psychology major with an excellent record and great promise of future achievement in the field

Senior Thesis High Honors, Tufts University Department of Psychology (2024). Evaluated by thesis chair and second reader on research design and methods, written work, and oral defense

Dean's List, Tufts University (2020 – 2024). Awarded to full-time students earning a minimum GPA of 3.4 each semester

Publications

Peer-Reviewed

1. Pizzagalli, D. A., Lam, C. S. T.*, **Syed, S.***, & Shiva, A.* (2026). Reward dysfunction in time: Toward a dynamic psychiatry of motivation and pleasure. *Biological Psychiatry: Global Open Science, 6*(6), Article 100801. **DOI** **Equal contributions*
2. Oh, S., Herrera, C.-N., Duncan, A., **Syed, S.**, Xu, C., Brown, E., Brown, H., Henderson, D., Were, L., & Oblath, R. (2026). Racial and ethnic variations in a multi-channel psychiatric emergency services program. *Community Mental Health Journal.* **DOI**
3. Oblath, R., Beaugard, C. A., Herrera, C.-N., Xu, C., **Syed, S.**, Sadatis, C., Duncan, A., Gann, G., Plange, E., Ferguson, T., Khan, S., Katkhuda, F., Henderson, D. C., Savage, J., & Morabito, M. S. (2025). Bridging crisis and care: Exploring the role of behavioral health professionals in a police co-response model. *Health & Justice, 13*(1), 72. **DOI**
4. Rudolph, K. A., Beaugard, C. A., Xu, C., **Syed, S.**, Duncan, A., Brown, H. E., Henderson, D. C., & Oblath, R. (2025). Psychiatric emergency service use trends: Adults experiencing homelessness in Massachusetts from 2005–2020. *Journal of Health Care for the Poor and Underserved, 36*(1), 240–256. **DOI**

Manuscripts Under Review

5. Dan, R.*, **Syed, S.***, Hutson, L. M., Brown, A. R., Palermo, E. H., Belleau, E. L., Kaiser, R. H., Du, F., & Pizzagalli, D. A. Brain age gap, cortisol reactivity, and developmental timing of childhood maltreatment in major depressive disorder. *Under review.* **Preprint** **Co-first authorship*
6. **Syed, S.**, Oh, S., Herrera, C. N., Ferguson, T., Brown, H. E., & Oblath, R. Elevated acuity in crisis: Clinical pathways in psychiatric emergency services among Asian American and Pacific Islanders. *Asian American Journal of Psychology. Under review.*
7. Cárdenas, S. I., Dan, R., Schoonmaker, J., **Syed, S.**, Brown, A., Hutson, L., Palermo, E., Hollman, S., Du, F., Marmarosh, C., & Pizzagalli, D. Attachment and fronto-limbic morphometry in women with depressive symptoms and childhood sexual abuse histories. *Under review.*
8. Herrera, C. N., **Syed, S.**, Freibott, C., Lipson, S. K., Duncan, A., & Clark, J. Assertion, adjudication, and shared decision making in psychiatric emergency services: Perspectives from youth of color and guardians. *Children and Youth Services Review. Revise and resubmit.*
9. Freibott, C., **Syed, S.**, Barnard, E., Herrera, C. N., Lipson, S. K., Duncan, A., & Clark, J. POC youth perceptions of sexual orientation and gender identity discrimination in mental healthcare settings. *International Journal of LGBTQ+ Youth Studies. Revise and resubmit.*

Manuscripts In Preparation

1. **Syed, S.***, Dan, R.*, Hutson, L. M., Brown, A. R., Palermo, E. H., Belleau, E., Du, F., & Pizzagalli, D. A. Glutamatergic and immuno-oxidative stress abnormalities in major depressive disorder: Links to early childhood maltreatment and lifetime stress. *In preparation.* **Co-first authorship*

Presentations

Poster Presentations

1. Cárdenas, S. I., Dan, R., Schoonmaker, J., **Syed, S.**, Brown, A., Hutson, L., Palermo, E., Hollman, S., Marmarosh, C., & Pizzagalli, D. A. (2026, November 11–13). Adult attachment and fronto-limbic morphometry in women with depressive symptoms and childhood sexual abuse histories. International Society for Developmental Psychobiology Annual Conference, New Orleans, LA.
2. **Syed, S.** (Presenter), Dan, R., Hutson, L. M., Brown, A. R., Palermo, E. H., Wang, C., Stein, A., Chen, X., Du, F., & Pizzagalli, D. A. (2025, September). Glutamatergic and immuno-oxidative stress abnormalities in major depressive disorder: Links to early childhood maltreatment and lifetime stress. Society for Research in Psychopathology Annual Conference, Los Angeles, CA. **Poster**

3. **Syed, S.** (Presenter), Dan, R., Palermo, E. H., Hutson, L. M., Brown, A. R., Zhu, C., Stein, A., Chen, X., Du, F., & Pizzagalli, D. A. (2025, February). Multi-modal investigation of the relationships between stress and brain aging. Annual Harvard Psychiatry Research Day, Boston, MA. **Poster**
4. **Syed, S.** (Presenter), Dan, R., Palermo, E. H., Hutson, L. M., Brown, A. R., Zhu, C., Stein, A., Chen, X., Du, F., & Pizzagalli, D. A. (2025, January). Multi-modal investigation of the relationships between stress and brain aging. Annual McLean Research Day, Belmont, MA. **Poster**
5. **Syed, S.** (Presenter), Herrera, C. N., Oh, S., Brown, H. E., & Oblath, R. (2024, April). Trends in psychiatric emergency service use by Asian American youth before and during the COVID-19 pandemic. Society of Pediatric Psychology Annual Conference, New Orleans, LA. **Poster**
6. Gouse, B. M., Baul, T., **Syed, S.**, Boliver, E., Lancet, J., & Brown, H. E. (2024, April). Burden of physical illness in schizophrenia: Exploring the impact of sociodemographic factors on risk of multimorbidity. Annual Congress of the Schizophrenia International Research Society, Florence, Italy. **Poster**
7. Oblath, R., Herrera, C. N., Xu, C., **Syed, S.**, Henderson, D. C., & Duncan, A. (2023, May). Racial and ethnic differences in pathways to care, diagnosis, and disposition among youth at a multi-modality psychiatric emergency services program. Annual Meeting of the American Psychiatric Association, San Francisco, CA. **Poster**
8. Herrera, C. N., **Syed, S.**, Freibott, C., Duncan, A., & Clark, J. (2023, May). Consequences from prior health care interactions on the use of psychiatric emergency services by youth of color. Annual Meeting of the American Psychiatric Association, San Francisco, CA.
9. Herrera, C. N., **Syed, S.**, Freibott, C., Duncan, A., & Clark, J. (2023, April). Shared decision making among youth of color, guardians, and clinicians during psychiatric emergency services visit. Society for Pediatric Psychology Annual Conference, Chicago, IL.

Conference Oral Presentations

1. Herrera, C. N., **Syed, S.** (Presenter), Freibott, C., Duncan, A., & Clark, J. (2022, November). **Shared decision making among youth of color, guardians, and care team during psychiatric emergency services visit**. Oral presentation, American Public Health Association Annual Meeting and Expo, Boston, MA. **Slides**
2. Freibott, C., **Syed, S.**, Duncan, A., Clark, J., & Herrera, C. N. (2022, November). **LGBTQ+ youth of color perceptions of sexual orientation and gender identity discrimination in mental health settings**. Oral presentation, American Public Health Association Annual Meeting and Expo, Boston, MA.

Internal Oral Presentations

1. **Syed, S.** (Presenter), Dan, R., Hutson, L. M., Brown, A. R., Palermo, E. H., & Pizzagalli, D. A. (2025, October). Multi-modal investigation of the relationships between stress and brain aging. Joint lab meeting, Lab for Affective and Translational Neuroscience & UC Irvine Noel Drury, M.D. Institute for Translational Depression Discoveries. **Slides**

Research Experience

Laboratory for Affective and Translational Neuroscience (PI: Diego Pizzagalli, PhD) June 2024 – Present
McLean Hospital Center for Depression, Anxiety, and Stress Research, Harvard Medical School *Belmont, MA*
Clinical Research Assistant II

- Directly manage NIH-funded study ***Early Life Stress and Depression: Molecular and Functional Imaging Approaches*** (R01 MH095809) investigating neurobiological mechanisms linking childhood sexual abuse and Major Depressive Disorder (MDD), using multimodal imaging (fMRI, MRS) and behavioral tasks (e.g., Emotional Conflict, Value of Control)
- Coordinate and guide participants with current and past MDD through recruitment, informed consent, clinical assessments, behavioral tasks, MRI/MRS sessions, and follow-up phases of the study
- Conduct detailed phone screenings (**n=350**) to evaluate eligibility based on psychiatric history, depressive symptoms, and childhood maltreatment or abuse
- Collect and process biological samples, including saliva and blood (DNA, RNA, serum, cortisol), using centrifugation, pipetting, and secure sample storage protocols
- Oversee study operations, such as IRB submissions and amendments, data preparation for grant reports, and semiannual submissions to the NIMH National Data Archives
- Lead team operations by organizing meetings and training and supervising **9 research assistants** and volunteers in both administrative and research procedures

Office of Clinical Assessment and Research, OCD Institute (PI: Martha Falkenstein, PhD) April 2026 – Present
McLean Hospital *Belmont, MA*
Clinical Research Assistant

- Support 2 NIH-funded Hybrid Type 1 Effectiveness-Implementation Trials: ***Boosting the Effectiveness of Exposure Therapy for OCD with a Scalable Digital Cognitive Intervention*** (K23MH126193), a smartphone-based Cognitive Bias Modification for Interpretation (CBM-I) intervention targeting interpretation bias, and ***Hybrid Effectiveness-Implementation Trial of a Scalable Intervention Targeting Postpartum Intrusive Thoughts*** (R01MH146063)
- Lead scheduling and delivery of up to 12 CBM-I training sessions per participant, aligned to each patient's OCD Institute treatment timeline
- Coordinate pre-, mid-, post-training, and 1- and 3-month follow-up clinical assessments; oversee ecological momentary assessment data collection fidelity
- Co-author CBM-I implementation-effectiveness manuscript; wrote the introduction and lead qualitative analysis, including open and axial coding of stakeholder and exit interviews on implementation barriers and facilitators

- Support adaptation and development of a postpartum single-session intervention integrating Project ACCEPT (Schleider, Northwestern University; Mohanty, Stony Brook University) and Preventing Postpartum Onset Distress (P-POD; Timpano, University of Miami), a 7-module postpartum anxiety program
- Apply the FRAME and ADAPT intervention adaptation frameworks to translate ACCEPT's adolescent-focused content and reformulate P-POD's multi-session curriculum for postpartum parents

Boston Emergency Services Team (PIs: Rachel Oblath & Carolina Herrera, PhD) January 2022 – April 2026
Boston Medical Center, Department of Psychiatry *Boston, MA*
Lead Undergraduate Research Assistant

- First-authored manuscript examining encounter setting, psychiatric diagnosis, and discharge disposition among Asian American adults and youth (**N = 38,170**) in a psychiatric emergency system; independently developed research questions and led all phases from conceptualization through manuscript preparation, including electronic health record data extraction and management and multivariate logistic regression analyses; under review at *Asian American Journal of Psychology*
- Conducted thematic analysis in NVivo from semi-structured interviews with patients, guardians, and clinicians; co-wrote manuscript sections, contributed to peer review response and revision, and supported data curation across 2 manuscripts in revision; findings presented orally at a national public health conference
- Conducted in-person survey data collection across 3 studies in psychiatric emergency departments and locked inpatient units, including medical chart review to assess patient stability and determine eligibility; administered the Suicide Implicit Association Test (SIAT) in a study of suicide risk, and structured surveys examining psychiatric crisis in relation to COVID-19 and extreme heat
- Conducted background literature review and led editorial revision, APA formatting, and reference management across 3 published manuscripts on racial disparities in emergency psychiatric care, psychiatric emergency service use among adults experiencing homelessness, and police–clinician co-response models for psychiatric crises

Wellness and Recovery After Psychosis Clinic (PIs: Hannah Brown & Brittany Gouse, MD) September 2023 – May 2024
Boston Medical Center, Department of Psychiatry *Boston, MA*
Undergraduate Research Assistant

- Authored literature reviews synthesizing evidence on characteristics and service patterns of high psychiatric emergency service utilizers with schizophrenia, informing study design and clinical framing for published manuscript
- Conducted systematic medical chart reviews and managed longitudinal data entry and quality control for the Massachusetts Psychosis Network Treatment Battery
- Led in-person recruitment of individuals with schizophrenia across clinical settings, adapting communication strategies to engage participants experiencing active psychotic symptoms; obtained informed consent and educated prospective participants on study procedures with clarity and clinical sensitivity

Disparities Research Unit (PI: Margarita Alegría, PhD) January 2024 – May 2024
Massachusetts General Hospital *Boston, MA*
Undergraduate Research Assistant

- Conducted phone interviews for the *Positive Minds–Strong Bodies* randomized controlled trial aimed at reducing symptoms of depression among older adults
- Administered a battery of psychiatric assessments by phone at 6- and 12-month follow-up, including the PHQ-9, Geriatric Anxiety Inventory, Hopkins Symptom Checklist-25, WHO Disability Assessment Schedule, PTSD Checklist for DSM-5, and Montreal Cognitive Assessment

Social Cognition Lab (Advisor: Keith Maddox, PhD) June 2023 – May 2024
Tufts University, Department of Psychology *Medford, MA*
Honors Thesis Student

- Designed and led a mixed-methods thesis investigating the role of symbolic racism and bias awareness on anticipated interracial anxiety among people of color
- Developed a Qualtrics-based experimental paradigm with deception to capture emotional shifts during anticipated cross-racial interactions; integrated validated survey instruments with original open-ended questions
- Authored and secured a rigorous IRB protocol and debriefing plan; recruited and managed a university-based participant sample
- Performed linear regression analysis in R and created a **77-code** qualitative coding framework in NVivo to extract and synthesize patterns from narrative responses
- Delivered a written thesis, oral defense, and symposium presentation, translating findings into actionable insights on racial bias and perception

Skills

Statistical Analysis: RStudio (intermediate), SPSS (beginner), Stata (beginner); data cleaning, coding, and organizing across multiple platforms
Qualitative Analysis: NVivo (advanced); coding and thematic analysis, codebook creation, querying and organizing large datasets, generating summaries and visualizations (e.g., word frequency, coding matrices)
Survey & Database: REDCap (advanced), Qualtrics (advanced); database and survey creation, including branching logic and calculated fields
Neuroimaging: fMRI behavioral task administration in MATLAB; MRI data preprocessing using fMRIPrep; EEG data collection (BrainVision Recorder) with a high-density 96-channel system, including electrode preparation and impedance management
Administrative: IRB protocol development and management; independently writing protocols, continuing reviews, amendments, and adverse events, and maintaining compliance records; participant recruitment advertising via clinical study recruitment companies (BuildClinical, CliniContact, Splash Clinical, UserInterviews), Facebook, and university job boards

Certifications and Training

[CONFIRM AND EDIT] CITI Program, Human Subjects Research (Biomedical) | CITI Program, Good Clinical Practice (GCP) | HIPAA Privacy and Security | MRI Safety (Level [1/2]), McLean Hospital Imaging Center | [phlebotomy / specimen handling, CPR-BLS, NIH data management: add if held]

Professional Affiliations

Member: American Public Health Association | Psi Chi | Society of Pediatric Psychology | Society for Research in Psychopathology

References

Diego A. Pizzagalli, PhD: Principal Investigator, Lab for Affective and Translational Neuroscience; Founding Director, Noel Drury, M.D. Institute for Translational Depression Discoveries; Distinguished Professor, Department of Psychiatry and Human Behavior & Department of Neurobiology and Behavior | **dap@mclean.harvard.edu**

Rachel Oblath, PhD: Principal Investigator, Boston Emergency Services Team Partnership for Behavioral Health, Racial, and Social Justice; Director of Research Methodology, Boston Medical Center Department of Psychiatry; Assistant Professor, Boston University Chobanian & Avedisian School of Medicine | **roblath@bu.edu**